

Satyagraha: Not Passive Resistance

Mahatma Gandhi

The force denoted by the term 'passive resistance' and translated into Hindi as nishkriya pratirodha is not very accurately described either by the original English phrase or by its Hindi rendering. Its correct description is satyagraha. Satyagraha was born in South Africa in 1908. There was no word in any Indian language denoting the power which our countrymen in South Africa invoked for the redress of their grievances. There was an English equivalent, namely, 'passive resistance', and we carried on with it. However, the need for a word to describe this unique power came to be increasingly felt, and it was decided to award a prize to anyone who could think of an appropriate term. A Gujarati-speaking gentleman submitted the word 'satyagraha', and it was adjudged the best.

'Passive resistance' conveyed the idea of the Suffragette Movement in England. Burning of houses by these women was called 'passive resistance' and so also their fasting in prison. All such acts might very well be 'passive resistance' but they were no satyagraha. It is said of 'passive resistance' that it is the weapon of the weak, but the power which is the subject of the article can be used only by the strong. This power is not 'passive' resistance; indeed it calls for intense activity. The movement in South Africa was not passive but active. The Indians of South Africa believed that Truth was their object, that Truth ever triumphs, and with this definiteness of purpose they persistently held on to Truth. They put up with all the suffering that this persistence implied. With the conviction that Truth is not to be renounced even unto death, they shed the fear of death. In the cause of Truth, the prison was a palace to them and its doors the gateway to freedom.

Satyagraha is not physical force. A satyagrahi does not inflict pain on the adversary; he does not seek his destruction. A satyagrahi never resorts to firearms. In the use of satyagraha, there is no ill will whatever.

Satyagraha is pure soul-force. Truth is the very substance of the soul. That is why this force is called satyagraha. The soul is informed with knowledge. In it burns the flame of love. If someone gives us pain through ignorance, we shall win him through love. 'Non-violence is the supreme dharma' is the proof of this power of love. Non-violence is a dormant state. In the waking state, it is love. Ruled by love, the world goes on. In English there is a saying, "Might Is Right." Then there is the doctrine of the survival of the fittest. Both these ideas are contradictory to the above principle. Neither is wholly true. If ill-will were the chief motive-force, the world would have been destroyed long ago; and neither would I have had the opportunity to write this article nor would the hopes of the readers be fulfilled. We are alive solely because of love. We are all ourselves the proof of this. Deluded by modern Western civilization, we have forgotten our ancient civilization and worship the might of arms.

We forget the principle of non-violence, which is the essence of all religions. The doctrine of arms stands for irreligion. It is due to the sway of that doctrine that a sanguinary war is raging in Europe.

In India also we find worship of arms. We see it even in that great work of Tulsidas. But it is seen in all the books that soul-force is the supreme power.

Rama stands for the soul and Ravana for the non-soul. The immense physical might of Ravana is as nothing compared to the soul-force of Rama. Ravana's ten heads are as straw to Rama. Rama is a yogi, he has conquered self and pride. He is 'placid equally in affluence and adversity'; he has 'neither attachment, nor the intoxication of status'. This represents the ultimate in satyagraha. The banner of satyagraha can again fly in the Indian sky and it is our duty to raise it. If we take recourse to satyagraha, we can conquer our conquerors the English, make them bow before our tremendous soul-force, and the issue will be of benefit to the whole world.

It is certain that India cannot rival Britain or Europe in force of arms. The British worship the war-god and they can all of them become, as they are becoming, bearers of arms. The hundreds of millions in India can never carry arms. They have made the religion of non-violence their own. It is impossible for the varnashrama system to disappear from India.

The way of varnashrama is a necessary law of nature. India, by making a judicious use of it, derives much benefit. Even the Muslims and the English in India observe this system to some extent. Outside of India, too, people follow it without being aware of it. So long as this institution of varnashrama exists in India, everyone cannot bear arms here. The highest place in India is assigned to the brahmana dharma-which is soul-force. Even the armed warrior does obeisance to the Brahmin. So long as this custom prevails, it is vain for us to aspire for equality with the West in force of arms.

It is our Kamadhenu. It brings good both to the satyagrahi and his adversary. It is ever victorious. For instance, Harishchandra was a satyagrahi, Prahlad was a satyagrahi, Mirabai was a satyagrahi. Daniel, Socrates and those Arabs who hurled themselves on the fire of the French artillery were all satyagrahis. We see from these examples that a satyagrahi does not fear for his body, he does not give up what he thinks is Truth; the word 'defeat' is not to be found in his dictionary, he does not wish for the destruction of his antagonist he does not vent anger on him; but has only compassion for him.

A satyagrahi does not wait for others, but throws himself into the fray, relying entirely on his own resources. He trusts that when the time comes, others will do likewise. His practice is his precept. Like air, satyagraha is all-pervading. It is infectious, which means that all people-big and small, men and women-can become satyagrahis. No one is kept out from the army of satyagrahis. A satyagrahi cannot perpetrate tyranny on anyone; he is not subdued through application of physical force; he does not strike at anyone. Just as anyone can resort to satyagraha, it can be resorted to in almost any situation.

People demand historical evidence in support of satyagraha. History is for the most part a record of armed activities. Natural activities find very little mention in it. Only uncommon activities strike us with wonder. Satyagraha has been used always and in all situations. The father and the son, the man and the wife are perpetually resorting to satyagraha, one towards the other. When a father gets angry and punishes the son, the son does not hit back with a weapon, he conquers his father's anger by submitting to him. The son refuses to be subdued by the unjust rule of his father but he puts up with the punishment that he may incur through disobeying the unjust father. We can similarly free ourselves of the unjust rule of the Government by defying the unjust rule and accepting the punishments that go with it. We do not bear malice towards the Government. When we set its fears at rest, when we do not desire to make armed assaults on the administrators, nor to unseat them from power, but only to get rid of their injustice, they will at once be subdued to our will.

The question is asked why we should call any rule unjust. In saying so, we ourselves assume the function of a judge. It is true. But in this world, we always have to act as judges for ourselves. That is why the satyagrahi does not strike his adversary with arms. If he has Truth on his side, he will win, and if his thought is faulty, he will suffer the consequences of his fault.

What is the good, they ask, of only one person opposing injustice; for he will be punished and destroyed, he will languish in prison or meet an untimely end through hanging. The objection is not valid. History shows that all reforms have begun with one person. Fruit is hard to come by without tapasya. The suffering that has to be undergone in satyagraha is tapasya in its purest form. Only when the tapasya is capable of bearing fruit do we have the fruit. This establishes the fact that when there is insufficient tapasya, the fruit is delayed. The tapasya of Jesus Christ, boundless though it was, was not sufficient for Europe's need. Europe has disapproved Christ. Through ignorance, it has disregarded Christ's pure way of life. Many Christs will have to offer themselves as sacrifice at the terrible altar of Europe, and only then will

realization dawn on that continent. But Jesus will always be the first among these. He has been the sower of the seed and his will therefore be the credit for raising the harvest.

It is said that it is a very difficult, if not an altogether impossible, task to educate ignorant peasants in satyagraha and that it is full of perils, for it is a very arduous business to transform unlettered ignorant people from one condition into another. Both the arguments are just silly. The people of India are perfectly fit to receive the training of satyagraha. India has knowledge of dharma, and where there is knowledge of dharma, satyagraha is a very simple matter. The people of India have drunk of the nectar of devotion. This great people overflows with faith. It is no difficult matter to lead such a people on to the right path of satyagraha. Some have a fear that once people get involved in satyagraha, they may at a later stage take to arms. This fear is illusory. From the path of satyagraha [clinging to truth], a transition to the path of a satyagraha [clinging to untruth] is impossible. It is possible of course that some people who believe in armed activity may mislead the satyagrahis by infiltrating into their ranks and later making them take to arms. This is possible in all enterprises. But as compared to other activities, it is less likely to happen in satyagraha, for their motives soon get exposed and when the people are not ready to take up arms, it becomes almost impossible to lead them on to that terrible path. The might of arms is directly opposed to the might of satyagraha. Just as darkness does not abide in light, soulless armed activity cannot enter the sun-like radiance of soul-force. Many Pathans took part in satyagraha in South Africa abiding by all the rules of satyagraha.

Then it is said that much suffering is involved in being a satyagrahi and that the entire people will not be willing to put up with this suffering. The objection is not valid. People in general always follow in the footsteps of the noble. There is no doubt that it is difficult to produce a satyagrahi leader. Our experience is that a satyagrahi needs many more virtues like self-control, fearlessness, etc., than are requisite for one who believes in armed action. The greatness of the man bearing arms does not lie in the superiority of the arms, nor does it lie in his physical prowess. It lies in his determination and fearlessness in face of death. General Gordon was a mighty warrior of the British Empire. In the statue that has been erected in his memory he has only a small baton in his hand. It goes to show that the strength of a warrior is not measured by reference to his weapons but by his firmness of mind. A satyagrahi needs millions of times more of such firmness than does a bearer of arms. The birth of such a man can bring about the salvation of India in no time. Not only India but the whole world awaits the advent of such a man. We may in the meanwhile prepare the ground as much as we can through satyagraha.

How can we make use of satyagraha in the present conditions?

Why should we take to satyagraha in the fight for freedom? We are all guilty of killing manliness. So long as our learned Annie Besant is in detention, it is an insult to our manhood. How can we secure her release through satyagraha? It may be that the Government has acted in good faith, that it has sufficient grounds for keeping her under detention. But, at any rate, the people are unhappy at her being deprived of her freedom. Annie Besant cannot be freed through armed action. No Indian will approve of such an action. We cannot secure her freedom by submitting petitions and the like. Much time has passed. We can all humbly inform the Government that if Mrs. Annie Besant is not released within the time limit prescribed by us, we will all be compelled to follow her path. It is possible that all of us do not like all her actions; but we find nothing in her actions which threatens the 'established Government' or the vested interests. Therefore we too by participating in her activities will ask for her lot, that is, we shall all court imprisonment. The members of our Legislative Assembly also can petition the Government and when the petition is not accepted, they can resign their membership. For swaraj also, satyagraha is the unfailing weapon. Satyagraha means that what we want is truth, that we deserve it and that we will work for it even unto death.

Nothing more need be said. Truth alone triumphs. There is no dharma higher than Truth. Truth always wins. We pray to God that in this sacred land we may bring about the reign of dharma by following satyagraha and that this, our country, may become an example for all to follow.



88 Generation: The Fight for Democracy

WYA member from Burma (in exile in Singapore)

In September 2006 I was in London finishing my Master's thesis; I was the lucky one amongst my classmates in Rangoon as I had been granted a visa to travel to the UK to do research for my thesis. Most of my classmates were back home trying to finish as well, but unlike me, they had to work from the meagre resources that the government allowed them at in the national library. As I sat in my room looking out into the courtyard of Goodenough College in London's Bloomsbury neighborhood, I was struck by the beauty of the day with the soft misty rain coming down over the green yard in the late summer morning. It filled me with a joy and gratefulness to be alive that quickly led to anxiety when I remembered I only had a short while before returning home. That the source of my anxiety was not my thesis deadline led me to a feeling of guilt; I didn't want to return to Rangoon and my life there. I was privileged, my father was in favor with the junta so I had been able to travel, but even if I hadn't given my thesis the boost that researching abroad would give it, I knew I would still receive my diploma.

I had to stop working as the anxiety and guilt were too strong. I suddenly didn't want to finish my thesis, I didn't want to receive my master's diploma, all I wanted was to stay overlooking the courtyard and rain. For the first time the injustice of my position came to me in its full force; it was unfair that I was in London while my friends were quarantined in Rangoon because they were not my father's children. I didn't do any more work that afternoon. I walked out into the rain and walked for hours until I had made my mind up: I would return. I would finish my thesis but I would reject the diploma that was awaiting as I could not continue to benefit while others suffered. I wasn't sure what I was going to do but return I must and from there things would fall into place. I went back to my room and found a note from a friend inviting me to a group discussion of some readings, a local chapter of some NGO, its name: the World Youth Alliance, and I decided to join her. It was the best decision I could have made, not just because my friend is one of the happiest people I know so that you cannot help but feel light around her, but because the reading being discussed was about a movement in Poland, against their communist regime. It made me want to take the Polish experience to Burma because of their ability to put their country's good before their own personal comfort and their ability to unite as one before a power that only looked to divide and control them.

I returned to Burma and for the year that followed I became ever more involved with the opposition, especially after the junta's ineffectiveness to aid our populations affected by the Tsunami and their aggressive reaction to the Saffron Revolution in August 2007 which led to the consolidation of the 88 generation group. The 88 generation began as a student group who took their name from the groups of dissidents in 1988 that had been crushed by the junta. They became stronger after Saffron because the torture of the monks enraged all our society. Never had the junta violated something so sacred for all of us; it was their torture that led me to finally confront all around me and join forces with 88. The response by the other Buddhists through the region and internationally heartened us onwards in the fight for our liberation. Once joining 88 I took to them the readings from the WYA track A on solidarity, with which we quickly identified. Just like Poland we had our own style of communism that was suppressing our freedom and liberties in the name of autocratic conservation of our precolonial culture, just like Poland we could only save ourselves and Burma if we worked together putting our common good above our personal

comfort and good. Many incarcerations followed, many died but we have continued fighting for those in jail, for those who still walk through the streets in relative 'liberty', for ourselves because we no longer want to just survive the regime, we want to build our society.



WYA Declaration on the Family

Brussels, Belgium 2004

Written for the Tenth Anniversary of the International Year of the Family, the Declaration on the Family formed a critical part of the Europe4Family bike-ride and celebrations. This WYA Declaration recognizes that the family is the most basic unit of society and the place where free and responsible citizens are best formed. In order to develop free and just societies, the family must be cultivated and protected in culture and law.

We affirm that the family is a school of deeper humanity; within which each member learns best what it means to be a human person. There, each member of the human family, from conception to natural death, experiences the gift of unconditional, enduring love. Thus each human person is carefully taught by the family to be responsible, to commit, to share, and to love.

Within the family children first come to understand their own intrinsic and inviolable human dignity. Through their complementary roles, mother and father, equal in dignity, show their children that the freedom of the human person is most fully and rightly lived in the gift of self. True love freely received and given within the family is an image of the transcendent love that makes possible the fulfillment and completion of every human being.

The family sustains society as it gives life to the next generation. It also has the privilege of forming free and responsible citizens, thus securing democracy. As the fundamental unit of society the family ensures the sustainability of civilization and culture. It takes on essential tasks in the care of all and especially the weakest and most vulnerable.

In honor of this joyful commemoration of the year of the family, we invite every individual to join us in solidarity and seek to strengthen his or her own family; we ask business, arts and media to support us by creating a family friendly climate; and we ask national, regional and international politicians to hear us and respond by creating the framework for a family friendly society.